Educational Outcomes for Children in Out-of-Home Placement

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MINNESOTA-LINK
Minnesota-Linking Information for Kids

Center for Advanced Studies in Child Welfare 20 YEARS

Research Questions & Method

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study was to explore the educational well-being of Minnesotan children whose out-of-home care experience occurred during the 2009-2010 academic year in conjunction with a child protection case.

Out-of-home placement refers to a situation in which children are placed away from their homes for purposes of care and/or treatment (Office of the Legislative Auditor, 1999), and includes settings such as foster homes, placement with a relative or friend, group homes, shelter care, residential treatment centers, and medical facilities.

Children may be placed out-of-home for a variety of reasons including, child abuse and/or neglect, child abandonment, parental or child substance abuse, parental incarceration, parental or child disability, child delinquency or status offenses, and child behavior problems.

Research Questions

1. What are the demographic characteristics of school-aged children in out-of-home care?
2. How are these children faring educationally in terms of their attendance, school mobility, special education status, and academic achievement?

Participants

1. Participants in the Education group were children in grades K-12 who attended public school in Minnesota during the 2009-2010 academic year (N=822,056).
2. A Child Protection group includes children who were involved in a child protection investigation or assessment case in Minnesota during the 2009-2010 academic year (N=10,678).
3. Two mutually exclusive groups were formed as a subset of the Child Protection group – Out-of-Home Placement (OHP; N=430) and Out-of-Home Placement Transfer (OHPT; N=39). The OHPT group experienced a transfer of schools during their placement whereas the OHP group did not.

Table 1. Demographic Characteristics by Group

	Education (N=822,056)	Child Protection (N=10,678)	OHP (N=469 OHP (N=430)	OHPT (N=39)
Female	48.50%	51.40%	57.70%	59.00%
Male	51.50%	48.60%	42.30%	41.00%
American Indian	2.30%	8.40%	6.00%	25.60%
Asian	6.30%	3.00%	3.00%	2.60%
Hispanic	6.70%	9.40%	6.50%	5.10%
Black	10.00%	22.50%	36.30%	23.10%
White	74.60%	56.70%	48.10%	43.60%
Reduced	7.70%	8.10%	6.00%	7.70%
Free Lunch	27.10%	68.10%	77.00%	56.40%
K	3.80%	6.50%	2.60%	7.70%
1	7.90%	13.30%	9.10%	5.10%
2	7.60%	11.40%	10.00%	2.60%
3	7.70%	10.30%	8.60%	7.70%
4	7.60%	9.40%	9.10%	5.10%
5	7.60%	8.90%	7.70%	5.10%
6	7.60%	7.40%	4.90%	17.90%
7	7.70%	7.10%	11.40%	7.70%
8	7.70%	6.30%	8.80%	17.90%
9	8.20%	7.00%	9.10%	5.10%
10	8.30%	6.10%	9.10%	12.80%
11	8.50%	4.50%	6.70%	2.60%
12	9.80%	1.70%	3.00%	2.60%

Data Analysis

To investigate associations between out-of-home placement and educational well-being, rates of Individualized Education Plan (IEP) utilization, school mobility, and MCA II achievement scores were compared among the four groups. A Bonferroni post-hoc analysis was primarily used to describe differences among the four groups.

Results

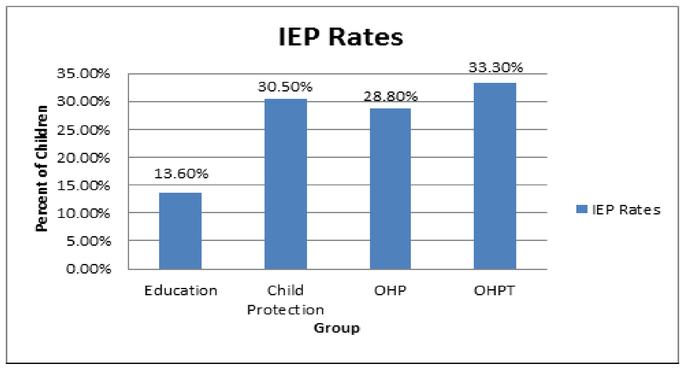


Figure 1. Rates of Individualized Education Plans by Group

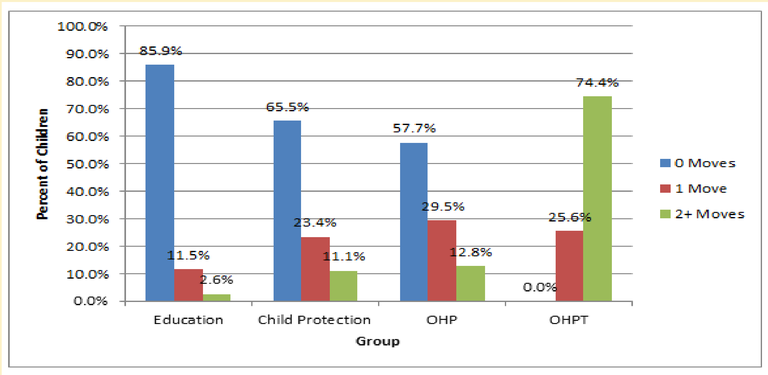


Figure 2. School Mobility by Group

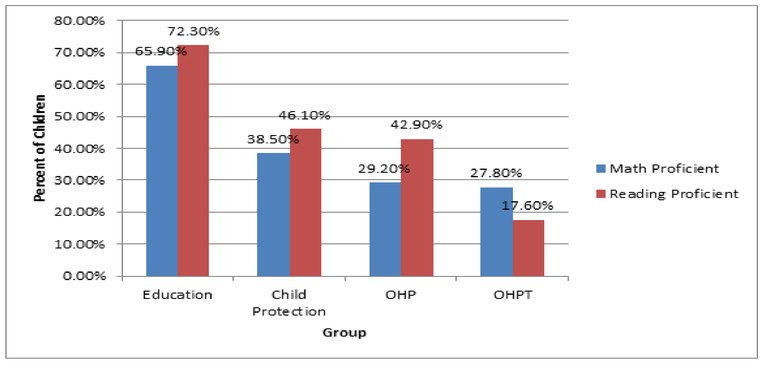


Figure 3. Overall MCA II Proficiency by Group

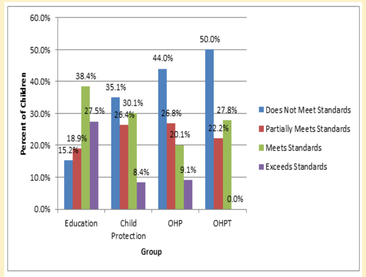


Figure 4. MCA II Proficiency Levels in Math by Group

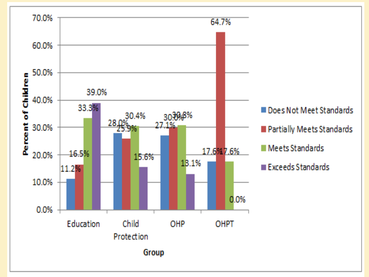


Figure 4. MCA II Proficiency Levels in Reading by Group

Conclusions

1. Children who are involved in child protection, and especially children who experience out-of-home placement, struggle in their educational well-being. Although less than 10% of all children in out-of-home care experienced school mobility (i.e., transferring schools within Minnesota) during their placement, those that did experience school mobility fared worst across all educational measures. Children involved in child protection, and children in out-of-home care especially, are significantly struggling in their performance on Minnesota's standardized assessments of academic achievement. Failure to demonstrate proficiency on Minnesota's standardized assessments jeopardizes children's' ability to graduate from high school. Proficiency on these standardized tests may be an early indicator of the likelihood of children successfully completing high school.
2. Research is needed to understand the effect of recent policy changes (such as Fostering Connections) on the educational well-being of children in out-of-home placement. Additional research is necessary to determine the effect of placement indicators, such as the number of placements, length of placement, and placement setting on children's educational outcomes. Once this information is learned, policies and interventions may be created to better support the educational well-being of children involved in child protection and children placed in out-of-home care.

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Minnesota Department of Education - education data containing demographic variables, gifted/talented status, grade-level test scores, graduation rates, attendance, and reasons for leaving school for academic years 2001-2011. An academic year runs from September through Jun so academic year 2001 covers enrollment between September 2000 through June 2001

Minnesota Department of Human Services - child protection maltreatment data from the Social Services Information System (SSIS) containing demographic variables, maltreatment data, investigation information, and placement information for the continuous time period of January 2000 through October 2012.

Minnesota Department of Health - data available via request for and establishment of an agreement with the Department of Health.

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